

Critical Reflection of Gender Inequality in Sports

Gender inequality refers to the unequal distribution of rights, resources, and opportunities based on gender (Plan International, 2024). Despite global efforts to promote gender equality, no country in the world has fully achieved it. Alarming statistics reveal that one in three countries have made no progress towards gender equality since 2015 (Focus 2023, 2024). Gender inequality stems from a long history of ingrained social structures, cultural norms, and power dynamics that have consistently favored men and marginalized women (Plan International, 2024). In fact, its roots can be traced back to when humans first began to settle and develop agriculture. Physiological differences, combined with societal and cultural factors, have historically placed men at the top of the social hierarchy, causing an undervaluation of women's capabilities and rights. (United Nations, 2023).

This inequality manifests today in disparities in between genders in economics, politics, education, healthcare, and sports (Plan International, 2024). A dominant belief in the 1800s was that humans had a fixed amount of energy to denote to physical and intellectual tasks. Menstruation was seen as a time of weakness for women, reinforcing the idea that females did not belong in the world of competitive sports (Bell, 2008).

A major turnaround point occurred when Katherine Switzer decided to run the Boston marathon, an event strictly allowed only to male athletes, by entering her name under "K.V. Switzer." While on the course she faced race directors attempting to physically remove her from the course along with verbal abuse telling her to get out of the race. Afterwards she was disqualified (*Katherine Switzer*, 2017). Switzer's bold action became a catalyst for change, helping pave the way for the creation of Title IX in 1972, which federally prohibits sex discrimination in sports (Bell, 2008). Despite major breakthroughs this inequality is still visible today through significant pay disparities

and unequal media representation of female athletes. Through a critical reflection of media portrayals and academic research this discussion will explore how systemic gender bias has shaped the literary portrayal of female athletes.

Critical Analysis:

The literary portrayal of female athletics through written, spoken, and visual aspects work together to obscure viewers and readers from recognizing the strengths and achievements of female athletes. All types of media portrayal have been found to consistently work to keep the historical and culturally rooted view of women as beautiful, properly behaved, and well-groomed (McDonald, 2014). One of the most notable differences in how written and spoken media portrays female versus male athletes lies in adjectives used in headlines and by commentators. These differences subconsciously shape ideas of strength and weakness in how viewers perceive athletes. For example, in 1992 Olympic coverage, words such as “aggressive” and “powerful” were found to be used over 185 times in men’s athletics compared to just 68 times in women’s competitions (Higgs et al., 2003). This trend appears again in gymnastics, where media coverage reveals a three-to-one ratio of strength descriptors for men compared to weakness descriptors for women. Men were described as “very aggressive”, “amazing”, and “going all out from start to finish,” while women were described using phrases like “little girl dancing for gold.” (Higgs et al., 2003).

In another shocking statistic media coverage showed a split in how often female athletes were described using masculine and feminine terms. From the already minimal coverage women received, 43% of the time they were described with feminine terms such as “ladies”, “cute”, and “dramatic.” The remaining 57% used masculine descriptors like “dominant”, “smooth”, “effortless” and “unstoppable” (Higgs et al., 2003). Even the very act of framing descriptors into “masculine” and “feminine” implies inequality, equating masculinity with dominance and strength, and

femininity with fragility and dependance. Supporting this, when adjectives used to describe men in sports were analyzed, 75% were associated with masculinity compared to only 25% with femininity (McDonald, 2014).

Overall, written and verbal media demonstrate that female athletes are often described in ways that emphasize their gender rather than their athleticism, strength, or performance (McDonald, 2014). Although the terminology is simple and widely accessible, the way it is used contributes to exclusion. People with limited access to education on gender inequality might absorb these portrayals without recognizing underlying bias, reinforcing stereotypes unknowingly. This leads to phrases like “she plays like a man” or “he throws like a boy” being perceived as memorable and even humorous, when in reality, they turn what could be compliments into subtle, derogatory statements that imply women are less skilled or important than men (McDonald, 2014). Rather than empowering, this accessible language spreads hidden messages that spread gender bias in sports.

Another critical part of literacy involved in women’s athletics is the visual representation of female athletes. Just like written and verbal portrayals, visual literacy follows the same pattern of presenting female athletes in ways that obscure their strengths and achievements. For instance, ESPN sports covers show clear differences in how male and female athletes are depicted (Figure 1).

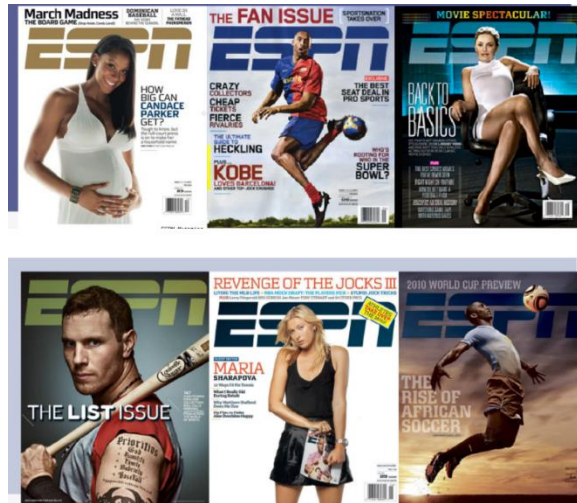


Figure 1: ESPN cover pictures of Professional Athletes (From: Turner, 2022).

In all the examples, female athletes are portrayed through a traditional lens focused on femininity, motherhood, beauty, grace, and aesthetics. The women are posed, smiling, facing the camera, and often dressed in tight clothing – in contrast to male athletes, who are shown in action poses that highlight endurance or strength (Turner, 2022). These visual differences portray female athletes as passive and male athletes as active and strong, which shapes how audiences perceive the value and seriousness of women’s sports (Turner, 2022).

A 2019 analysis of Instagram images from NBC, ESPN, FOX sports, and CBS sports found that only a small percentage of female athletes were shown in full uniforms or active poses, with most images capturing them outside of competition in passive stances. In contrast, male athletes were shown in action 80% of the time (Romney & Johnson, 2019). Similarly, a Sports Illustrated review found that only 34% of female athlete images showed them in game action, 55% placed them in non-sport settings, and 5% in sexualized poses - compared to 66%, 23%, and 0% respectively for male athletes (McDonald, 2012).

Visual literacy becomes as powerful as what we read, repeating gendered ideas through imagery. This kind of media targets general sports fans and casual viewers, who often rely on surface-level portrayals. Because these viewers often lack access to deeper commentary about gender inequality, they are more susceptible to absorbing biased visual cues without question.

Beyond differences in literacy, women also face broader challenges such as pay inequality and disproportionate media coverage. When discussing the pay gap, most media outlets stick to basic numbers: “the top ten highest paid female athletes combined earned \$105,000,000. The three top earning male athletes over the same period each earned more than \$105,000,000 each” (Ramdat, 2021). This kind of coverage typically concludes with the simplified reasoning that, “men’s sports generate more revenue” (Morgan, 2021). However, this critical analysis shows that revenue differences alone do not explain inequality. In reality, “the wage gap is both a revenue and gender issue...men’s sports generate more revenue than women’s sports in part because consumer performances are rooted in internalized racism, sexism, and homophobia” (Morgan, 2021).

Comparisons between platforms like SportsCenter and FOX Sports 1 further support this. Both networks feature women’s sports in less than 2% of their content, regardless of the time frame, and devoted far less time to women’s stories compared to men’s (Billings & Young, 2015). These trends expose a deeper truth: literacy surrounding women’s sports is not only limited, it is often misleading accessing a wide array of people due to presence on television, radio, and newspapers.

Additionally, terms like “Title IX compliance” or “collective bargaining” are essential for understanding the systems behind gender inequality in sports. Yet these terms are often presented without explanation, making them inaccessible to those without a background in law or policy. This creates communication barriers that prevent the public from fully understanding or engaging with

this issue. As a result, the very people most affected by these policies (athletes, fans, and general public) are left without the knowledge to challenge or question gender inequality and instead given the tool to participate in it, allowing the problem to persist.

Critical Reflection:

A powerful initiative that aligns perfectly with the goal of challenging gender inequality in sports is the #CoverTheAthlete social media campaign. This campaign went viral in 2015, using satire and visual storytelling to call out sexist media coverage that female athletes regularly face. Within the one-minute and thirty-second video, interviewers reversed traditional interview questions typically directed at female athletes by asking male athletes questions like “Could you give us a twirl?” or “How do you maintain your physique?” (*Cover the Athlete*, 2018). The campaign highlighted how female athletes are often asked superficial, gendered questions that undermine their athletic ability and place emphasis on their gender.

The target audience for this campaign was the general public, especially sports fans and media consumers who may not have realized the extent of gender bias in coverage, as previous media literacy practices obscure the gendered differences to appear that it is normal. The expected literacy level was broad and inclusive to most groups as the short video relied on humor, irony, and simple language to make it accessible to all audiences without prior knowledge on gender inequality. Its accessibility was particularly effective due to use of easily sharable content in a viral-friendly format. The video’s brief length and its use of a hashtag allowed for widespread circulation, making the message about gender inequality clear and compelling.

Despite its success, there are still communication barriers present. While this format was effective for starting a conversation, it lacks depth in addressing the structural causes behind the media’s treatment of female athletes. This absence of context may limit the audience’s ability to take

more meaningful action or connect media representation to deeper issues like the pay gap. Additionally, individuals unfamiliar with media strategies might find the video humorous rather than as a call to reflect, change, and take action against gender inequality. However, these barriers are limited as the campaign intentionally used universally understandable humor, ensuring the core message of challenging sexist treatment of females would resonate with a wide audience. By lowering the literacy threshold and centering on emotional engagement, the campaign succeeds in planting awareness despite not offering tools for deeper awareness.

Exploring the gender inequality that persists in sports has revealed how deeply literacy shapes public understanding and response to societal issues. The #CoverTheAthelete campaign highlights how the media minimizes female athletes, viewing them through a gendered lens rather than focusing on accomplishments. While campaigns like this make gender inequality in sports more visible, they also rely on audiences' ability to engage with the media in a way that reveals the deeper, structural problems with inequality without doing it itself.

I was particularly drawn to gender inequality in sports because of one of my personal role model's experiences with it. As a track and field athlete myself, Allyson Felix, an American sprinter who is the most decorated female Olympian ever in track and field with a total of 11 Olympic medals – 7 gold, 3 silver, and 1 bronze (*Allyson Felix | Biography, Medals, TED Talk, & Facts | Britannica*, 2023) is one of my biggest role models. Felix faced backlash upon bringing up the idea of starting a family. Previously signed with Nike, Felix was told to “know her place” and that runners had to run. If she got pregnant and started a family, an idea associated with femininity, she would be viewed as weak and unable to return to competition. When her contract was up for renewal, Nike proposed a 70% pay cut and reduced guarantees if she did not perform well after childbirth (Felix, 2019). This penalty is something male athletes would never face under similar circumstances.

In response, Felix left Nike and signed a deal with Athleta, a brand that provided her the maternity protections she deserved. She later founded her own brand, Saysh, designed for and by women. Felix voiced her story to United States Congress, and her experience became a hot topic in 2019. What makes her story particularly relevant was the medium through which it was delivered: an op-ed in the *New York Times* titled “Nike Told Me to Know My Place”. While this platform may not have been instantly viral as #CoverTheAthlete campaign due to its delivery, Felix’s reputation and the emotional weight of her story allowed it to spread widely. Soon after, Nike revised its maternity policy (Felix, 2019). Like #CoverTheAthlete, Felix translated the injustices she faced into a message the public could understand. Both show how media narratives often reduce female athletes to appearances, relationships, or emotions rather than their achievements.

In summary, literacy has affected the communication of gender inequality in two major ways. It enhances the issue by obscuring female athletic success and strength, making it harder for the public to recognize the problem without prior knowledge in systemic inequalities and sports and media jargon. Literacy also serves as a tool that translates the issue of gender inequality in sports into something the public can understand, engage with, and act on – as seen in Felix’s actions and the campaign #CoverTheAthlete. However, the same literacies that empower also contribute to misunderstanding, excluding, or accidentally supporting the inequality clearly evident in sports towards women. Literacy determines who gets heard, believed, and what gets changed. If a real push for gender equity in sports were to occur, we need to improve on how media communication about female athletes not just in what it says, but also how it says it.

Recommendations:

To work towards equality there are several steps the public can take. The best way to determine what would work best to cause change in gender inequality in sports is to reflect and use

what has worked in the past (like Felix's actions in speaking out and the #CoverTheAthlete campaign). These examples highlight the power of accessible and emotional media to raise awareness and spark real policy change. For this reason, some strategies to address the gap in communication and realization of gender inequality as an issue include:

1. Multimedia Storytelling (like Felix and the #CoverTheAthlete Campaign)

Through the use of visual and audio content more complex issues can be broken down for audiences who may not connect with dense articles on gender inequality as a societal issue. Creating short documentaries, podcasts, Instagram reels, TikTok's, or YouTube Shorts that highlight stories (like Allyson Felix's) can bring the differences in media treatment to life. If these videos go viral it increases the chances conversations will be sparked, and real change will occur (like how Nike changed their policies regarding maternity protection after Allyson Felix spoke up) (Felix, 2022).

2. Partner with more Athletes to Advocate for Gender Inequality

Similar to the previous point, one the hardest challenges with enacting change for a societal issue is getting the issue communicated to the general public. As stated throughout this reflection, the literacy involved with gender inequality in sports currently just enhances the issue. By pairing gender inequality campaigns with athletes, who already have a large platform that reach many people, the chances that more individuals become aware/educated of the current issue can increase drastically.

3. Utilize more Hashtag Campaigns that Encourage Participation

Similar to the #CoverTheAthlete campaign it has been found that the simple use of the hashtag over social media drastically increases the effectiveness of social media advocacy (Saxton et al., 2015). Utilizing a hashtag increases the number of retweets/reposts on media specifically when it is used to advance organizational and advocacy messaging. The

difference between “#cancer” and “#CancerSucks” are the memorability of the message (Saxton et al., 2015). By using a hashtag in a way that prompts advocacy (which is what would be used here. Ex: #SameSportSameRespect) the message can be spread more effectively. If we work to make gender inequality more memorable/at the forefront of peoples minds when people view sports media whether written, verbal, or visual it should decrease the chances of them falling trap to repeating derogatory comments towards female athletes and/or subconsciously accepting the message that female athletes are less than male athletes.

4. Host Workshops for Media Broadcasters on the Systemic Issues of Gender Inequality

One of the main reasons gender inequalities in sports flies under many individuals’ radars is that the simple difference in vocabulary used to describe female athletes repeatedly works to ensure female athletes aren’t viewed of as strong or successful as male athletes. To prevent this from occurring we can attack the problem right at the source. As a society we could have future media broadcasters participate in workshops/simple activities such as participating in interactive websites that require individuals to edit sports media coverage to make it more equitable. It has been proved time and time again that an active learning process increases the chances of retention and application of information in comparison to just listening (Reuell, 2019). So, by having broadcasters participate in these workshops every so often it increases the chances they will be more aware of the literacy they use when broadcasting women’s sports.

5. Gear Female Athlete Pictures towards Action/Movement Shots rather than Passive/Posed

One of the changes societies can make that would have profound impacts on the communication of gender inequality in sports is to simply start picturing female athletes in

the way that male athletes are pictured. It has been found that when individuals view images of athletes in active, strong poses they think of female athletes as “role models and remarked that they transgressed traditional gender stereotypes” (Daniels, 2012). However, when viewing more sexualized/posed female athletes individuals made remarks that “objectified appraisals of the athletes” (Daniels, 2012) and “levied critiques about women’s status in society” (Daniels, 2012). These findings suggest that by creating more performance imagery of female athletes (Figure 2) in mainstream media will decrease the chances people participate in gender inequality as well as increase the chances individuals at least start to view female athletes more as equals.



Figure 2: Female Athlete in Action Shot (From: Anderson, 2012)

As the issue will stop being communicated as not an issue and start being communicated as one. As an added side note when asking AI to generate examples of action poses for female athletes, as it was also difficult to find one in real life, every single attempt prompted poses that can be deemed sexualized. This again, proves the urgency to which we need to address gender inequality in sports through changes in literacy that allow the public to not absorb gender inequality but instead reprimand it.

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